Top WiFi 6 solutions providers for enterprises

WiFi 6 is targeted for areas that have many devices connecting to one network, and is more than just a collection of access points. It enables superior security and performance, centralised configuration and management, and a much higher capacity for user density.

Arista's cognitive WiFi 6 platforms remove any single points of failure for seamless and limitless scaling. Its CloudVision WiFi uses Big Data analysis to proactively identify and remediate inefficiencies that end-user wireless experiences often encounter.

Cisco Meraki uses WiFi 6 multigigabit technology, allowing you to optimise wireless access with faster connections, greater user capacity, and more coverage. It also includes integration benefits for organisations that have other Cisco and Meraki components on their network.

Ruckus, which is currently owned by parent company Arris, not only sells WiFi 6 hardware products but also provides software solutions. Its 'ultra-high density technology suite' is designed to improve network performance in high density areas.

Extreme Networks, now acquired by Aerohive, specialises in on-premises wireless controllers and WiFi 6 compatible distributed architecture. This provides administrators the authority to tune and control networks with added resiliency when compared to cloud managed alternatives.

Fortinet is known for its security-centric systems. Admins can manage via a dedicated, on-premises WiFi 6 compatible controller or by using a cloud-managed service option. FortiNAC is a network access control platform that integrates into any wireless architecture options to provide access and monitoring of wireless users, as well as autonomous IoT devices.

Top Wi-Fi 6 solutions providers for homes

Deploying a Wi-Fi 6 router can be challenging, as the pricing is based on hardware specs, performance capabilities, and features. Budget Wi-Fi 6 routers — typically, bare-bones and dual-band models — range in price from US$ 70 to US$ 200. They use low-end components such as dual-core CPUs that offer low data rates, and lack features such as USB ports, anti-malware software, and multi-gig LAN ports. A high-end Wi-Fi 6 router costs more than US$ 600.

WiFi 6 whole-home mesh networking system routers come at a very economical price, and are being chosen by vendors who provide home-based solutions. It is easier and quicker to operate them when compared to adding a third-party wireless range extender to the network.

TP-Link Archer AX6000 Wi-Fi 6 router delivers speeds up to 5952 Mbps and comes with eight external antennas that provide a stronger connectivity throughout your house. Its features include band steering and airtime fairness, which direct clients to the less congested band and optimise time usage, respectively. It comes with a security system built-in for parental controls as well.

Asus AX3000 Wi-Fi 6 router has a 160MHz bandwidth and a total networking speed of around 3000 Mbps. It helps to improve the battery life of the connected devices with its power saving feature. Since it is compatible with the Asus AiMesh, it offers seamless connectivity to all corners of your house.

Netgear Nighthawk Pro Gaming 6-Stream Wi-Fi router is basically designed for gaming. Its design handles VR gaming, 4K streaming and more. With a WPA3 encryption, traffic controller firewall (apart from the anti-virus), anti-malware and data protection, it offers excellent security.

The challenges

WiFi 6 does not promise an increase in speed, but is an upgrade designed to make sure the speeds of our devices within a given range/area doesn't slow down a few years down the road. There are three major challenges it faces though, which are often overlooked.

Improving the functionality of unsupported devices: Even though WiFi 6 is backward- compatible, justice to it can only be done when this technology is used to the maximum. This means devices need to be upgraded each time.

Speed and performance outside the internal network: WiFi 6 can provide excellent connectivity for services like cloud file shares. However, the assets and resources of ISPs can affect speed and performance.

Coverage issues: Transmission and bandwidths are capped according to the regulations prevalent in each country. Hence, the coverage of WiFi 6 may be restricted to ensure this cap is met.

In spite of these challenges, companies like Aruba, Asus, AT&T, Boingo, Broadcom, Cisco, Comcast, CommScope, Cypress, Extreme Networks, Intel, Netgear, Orange, Qualcomm, TP-Link and Xiaomi are all focusing on the potential WiFi 6 has. END

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